told me. One of those seats was won by defeating Telangana Chief Minister K.C. Rao's daughter K. Kavitha in Nizamabad. Another key seat was wrested by the BJP's new Hindutva icon in Telangana, Bandi Sanjay Kumar, who defeated TRS stalwart B. Vinod Kumar in Karimnagar—a constituency KCR himself had won from in 2004. Following this victory, the BJP appointed Sanjay Kumar as its Telangana president in March 2020. The former RSS and ABVP leader has a hard-line Hindutva reputation and his appointment indicated the party's new strategy. 'If they play their cards right, they have a fantastic chance to do something in Telangana,' said a BJP strategist in Bengaluru. 'The win in Karimnagar was important because it was so close to KCR. It was the place of the launch of fight for Telangana. He hit them inside their house. BJP was never taken seriously there but he did this. He is aggressive and sharp.'

In the months leading up to his appointment as Telangana BJP chief, Sanjay Kumar announced that the BJP would 'fly the saffron flag on Golconda Fort sooner than later'. After stones were thrown at a BJP rally in Hanamkonda, he also sent Asaduddin Owaisi's AIMIM and Telangana's ruling TRS a sharp message: 'If they use sticks to attack us, we will retaliate with knives, and if knives are used, we will respond with guns. The war has already begun.'[121]

In the same vein, when the Telangana government adopted a resolution in the state assembly against CAA, NPR and NRC, the BJP state unit president announced that, if Chief Minister K. Chandrashekhar Rao and Asaduddin Owaisi did not want to register for NPR due to political reasons, they could 'seek refuge in Pakistan'.[122] Just as Karnataka was built as a BJP bastion because of its local leadership and 'local spine', the party was now looking to grow in Telangana through aggressive Hindutva positioning.

It is a sign of how serious the BJP is about Telangana that a number of Karnataka BJP leaders were sent to the state in 2019 to oversee the poll campaign. The first-time BJP MP from Secunderabad, G. Kishan Reddy, was appointed minister of state for home affairs in the second Modi government. Another sign of this new focus on the state was the sheer central leadership firepower deployed in a Hyderabad municipal poll in December 2020. The result was that, in a city where almost every second voter is Muslim,